

ADHD CHILD PARENTING STRATEGY GUIDE

Visual Schedules, Reward Systems & Coping Tools (Ages 4-12)

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WHY TRADITIONAL PARENTING FAILS ADHD KIDS

ADHD brains process rewards, time, and motivation differently.

- VISUAL systems (can't hold info in working memory)
- IMMEDIATE rewards (delayed gratification is harder)
- SHORTER tasks (break everything into 5-10 min chunks)
- MOVEMENT breaks (sitting still depletes energy)
- CONNECTION before correction (shame makes ADHD worse)

MORNING ROUTINE VISUAL CHART

(Laminate and hang in bedroom/bathroom!)

[1] ☐ Wake up

[2] ☐ Bathroom

[3] ☐ Brush teeth (2 min timer)

[4] ☐ Get dressed (clothes laid out night before)

[5] ☐ Eat breakfast

[6] ☐ Pack backpack

[7] ☐ Shoes on

[8] ☐ OUT THE DOOR by ____:____

TIP: Child checks off steps themselves!

AFTER-SCHOOL ROUTINE

- [1] ☐ Snack (15 min)
- [2] ☐ Movement break (10 min - run/jump/dance)
- [3] ☐ Homework (timer: ____ min)
- [4] ☐ Break (5 min)
- [5] ☐ Free time / play
- [6] ☐ Dinner
- [7] ☐ Evening routine

KEY: Movement BEFORE homework!

BEDTIME ROUTINE

- [1] ☐ Screens OFF (30 min before bed)
- [2] ☐ Bath/shower
- [3] ☐ Pajamas
- [4] ☐ Brush teeth
- [5] ☐ Pick tomorrow's clothes
- [6] ☐ Read/audiobook
- [7] ☐ Calm activity
- [8] ☐ Lights out ____:____

ADHD-FRIENDLY REWARD SYSTEM

EARN TOKENS:

- Routine completed without reminders = 2 tokens
- Homework done with timer = 2 tokens
- Kind to siblings = 1 token
- Remembered task without reminding = 2 tokens
- Tried something hard = 1 token

SPEND TOKENS:

- 5 tokens = Extra screen time (30 min)
- 10 tokens = Choose dinner menu
- 15 tokens = Special outing with parent
- 20 tokens = Small toy or book
- 30 tokens = BIG reward (you choose!)

TOKEN TRACKER:

[][][][][][][][][]

[][][][][][][][][][]

[][][][][][][][][][]

HOMEWORK STATION SETUP

- Visual timer (Time Timer or sand timer)
- Fidget tool (tangle, putty, or stress ball)
- Noise-canceling headphones or white noise
- All supplies within arm's reach
- Water bottle filled
- Clear desk - nothing extra
- Assignment checklist visible

STRATEGY: 10 min work -> 3 min break -> repeat

SENSORY BREAK MENU

HIGH ENERGY:

- Jump on trampoline
- Run laps outside
- Dance to one song
- Jumping jacks (20)
- Wall push-ups (10)

CALMING:

- Tight hug or weighted blanket
- Swing for 5 minutes
- Water play at sink
- Listen to calm music
- Blow bubbles (slow breathing)

FOCUSING:

- Chew gum
- Use fidget tool
- Cold water on wrists
- Full body stretch
- 5 deep belly breaths

IEP/504 PLAN PREPARATION WORKSHEET

Child's name: _____ Grade: _____

Diagnosis: _____ Date: ____/____/____

Child's strengths: _____

Areas of challenge: _____

Accommodations to request:

- ☐ Extended time on tests
- ☐ Preferential seating (near teacher)
- ☐ Movement breaks every 20 min
- ☐ Chunked assignments
- ☐ Visual schedules provided
- ☐ Fidget tools allowed in class
- ☐ Reduced homework load
- ☐ Check-in system with teacher
- ☐ Copy of notes provided
- ☐ Separate testing environment

TEACHER COMMUNICATION TEMPLATE

Dear [Teacher],
My child [name] has ADHD. Here is what helps them succeed:

WORKS WELL: _____

STRUGGLES WITH: _____

TRIGGERS: _____

CALMING STRATEGIES: _____

BEST CONTACT METHOD: _____

I'd love to schedule a brief meeting to discuss strategies.

Thank you, [Your name]

By Daniel Tesfamariam | ADHD is a superpower with the right support.